Reading the Baby's Signals

Civic Skill: Voice & Participation | EYLF: EYLF Outcome 2 (Community) & Outcome 3 (Wellbeing) | Duration: 20–30 minutes | Age: 4–6 years

LEARNING INTENTION

Drawing on Cheeseman's reimagined Pathway to Participation for infants and toddlers, children will practise noticing and interpreting the non-verbal 'voice' of babies and very young children, building empathy for participation rights across all ages.

SUCCESS CRITERIA

- I can name a way a baby tells us what they want without talking.
- I can watch carefully before deciding what a baby needs.
- I can explain why waiting and watching is a kind of listening.

MATERIALS

- Photographs (or a short, pre-approved video clip) showing babies displaying different cues — reaching, turning away, smiling, grizzling
- A baby doll
- Picture book featuring a baby sibling, e.g. 'Peekaboo Baby' by Kaaren Pixton

ACTIVITY STEPS

1. OPENING CIRCLE (4 min): 'Babies can't use words yet. Do you think they still have things to tell us?' Take responses. Introduce the idea of a baby's 'signals.'

2. PHOTO SORTING GAME (7 min): Children look at photo cards of babies' faces and bodies and guess what the baby might be showing. Prompt: 'I think the baby wants ___ because ___.'

3. DOLL ROLE-PLAY (8 min): In pairs, one child holds the doll and 'reads' its signals (using cue prompts from the educator — arms up, turning head, going still) while their partner interprets aloud.

4. DISCUSSION CIRCLE (6 min): 'How is listening to a baby different from listening to a friend? What do we have to do instead of just hearing words?' Introduce the phrase 'watch and wait.'

5. CLOSING (2 min): 'Watch and wait' becomes today's mantra — practise it together with a slow breath and open eyes.

EXTENSIONS	ASSESSMENT
• If possible, arrange a supervised, brief visit to the babies'/toddlers' room to practise real observation • Create a simple 'Signal Spotter' chart the group adds to over the week • Connect to real siblings — invite children to share a signal a baby brother or sister uses at home	• Note the language children use to interpret cues — does it move beyond guessing to reasoned observation? • Observe patience and waiting behaviour during the role-play • Learning story: document a genuine moment of a child 'reading' another's non-verbal cue during the week

EDUCATOR REFLECTION QUESTIONS

- How does this activity connect to Cheeseman's idea of moving the emphasis from what the adult does to what the adult notices?
- Did children show more patience with the doll than they typically do with peers? What might explain that?
- How might you model 'watch and wait' yourself, especially with the youngest or quietest children in your room?

EYLF LINKS

This lesson directly supports EYLF Outcome 2 (Community) & Outcome 3 (Wellbeing). Educators should record observations using anecdotal notes, photographs, or learning stories focused on children's language, body responses, and social interactions during the session.